

THE PRODUCTION PROCESS

The journey of tea from leaf to cup begins at the tea estate, where growers carefully nurture the leaf and prepare it for commercial production.

TYPES OF TEA ESTATES

Tea is grown on farms, or “estates,” that vary hugely in size, and range from small “gardens,” which are under 25 acres (10 hectares), to “plantations” spread over thousands of acres employing a large number of workers. While the aim remains the same regardless of the size of the tea estate, the difference lies in the intensity and scope of production. All estates tailor their tea to suit the taste of the market they cater to, and this influences the way the tea is grown and produced. Larger estates sell their yield by the ton, at auction and through brokers, transporting it to its destination by container ships, while smaller estates often sell directly to importers, wholesalers, and retailers.

INDUSTRIAL TEA ESTATES

As these estates grow tea mainly for commercial purposes, the focus is on quick and cheap production with few deviations from the tried and tested cultivars. Hence, large industrial tea estates use chemical fertilizers and pesticides to ensure a good harvest, and factory machinery to hasten the processing.

SINGLE ORIGIN ESTATES

Some large tea gardens take immense pride in their heritage. They are known for producing fine loose-leaf teas that are not blended with leaves from other farms. Known as single estate teas or single origin teas, these teas are valued for their unique flavor characteristics, which are particular to the terroir of the estate on which they are grown. As such, they don’t strive to be consistent in flavor year on year in the same way as industrial tea estates.



GARDENSCAPES

Some gardens form stunning undulating landscapes, while others are in straight rows.



ARTISAN GARDENS

Another category of tea estate is the artisan garden, which is smaller than a single origin estate, usually less than 25 acres (10 hectares). The success of an artisan garden lies in the grower’s understanding of the tea plant’s natural responses to its habitat, and their expertise in manipulating its plucked leaves. From tending the plant to sharing a cup with a buyer, the artisan tea maker has a hands-on approach throughout the entire process.

SINGLE ORIGIN

ONE OF A KIND

Teas from single origin estates are sought after for their signature style.